

Hijacked Jets Hit Trade Towers In N.Y. and Plow Into Pentagon

Death Grips The Heart Of Lower Manhattan

By Peter Slevin and Barton Gellman
Washington Post Service

NEW YORK — Jet-fuel fireballs billowed orange Tuesday morning when two jetliners powered into the tallest buildings on the New York City skyline.

The air quickly turned black and acrid, and some workers jumped from shattered windows of the World Trade Center's twin towers as debris and shredded office supplies showered the streets of lower Manhattan.

Refugees from the burning buildings raced and staggered outside into what had been a crystalline day only a few minutes earlier. Some screamed, others cried out, others sat on curbsides in mute shock, their faces and their business suits streaked with soot. The unhurt supported the wounded, with one man helping a stranger who had lost much of his skin.

Terrorists had exploded their bombs before, including one at this very same place in February 1993. But no one had ever experienced anything as stunning as the attack Tuesday on the World Trade Center. Witnesses described watching one of the towers collapse, saying it looked as though one of the best-known landmarks in the country had melted.

A fireman, draped in soot, lined up victims beside the smoldering buildings.

"Some were alive, some were dead, some were really badly burned," said the firefighter, Carlos Muniz. "It just rained and rained soot, and it was dark."

Mayor Rudolph Giuliani said the attack had caused a "horrendous number of lives lost" at the twin towers, where 50,000 people worked. The first plane hit shortly before 9 a.m., and the second about 25 minutes later. No accurate estimate of the number of casualties was available Tuesday afternoon.

Mr. Giuliani ordered an evacuation of the lower part of Manhattan and said the primary election for mayor and other offices in New York City had been postponed. Subway service stopped and airports were closed. With cellular telephone systems out of service, Manhattanites lined up at phone booths.

Clusters of people gathered around hot dog stands to listen to radios. Parents pulled their children from schools. The governor of New York, George Pataki, announced that he was sending in National Guard units.

Valerie Johnson stood in Foley Square, which became a staging area for fire and rescue teams that arrived from miles away. They tended the wounded as a long lick of flame crawled toward the top of one of the two towers. Ms. Johnson screamed: "My niece works in 7 World Trade Center. I'm trying to get in touch with someone. Oh God, oh God."

Black and gray clouds enveloped the buildings. An enormous rumble, described by a witness as sounding like thunder, only lasting longer, shook the ground. One of the buildings began to collapse. A few moments later, witnesses said, the top of the tower was not there.

Viewed from several miles away on the Long Island Expressway, where traffic came to a stop, the blackened towers looked to one witness like smokestacks, or burning cigarettes.

On the ground, well-heeled and casually dressed workers alike streamed north, away from the towers and the financial district. Many gasped and cried.

See NEW YORK, Page 8

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The Associated Press

A second airliner flying toward destruction at the World Trade Center on Tuesday. Minutes before, another jet had hit the complex.



Win McNamee/Reuters

President George W. Bush asking for a moment of silence Tuesday. Facing his first major crisis, he assailed the attacks. Later, aides said he would return to the White House. Page 8.

For Washington, a Modern Pearl Harbor

Like the Attack in 1941, Air Terrorism Could Provoke Severe Repercussions

By Joseph Fitchett
International Herald Tribune

PARIS — Sending airliners like huge suicide bombers to devastate the symbolic nerve centers of American power, the masterminds of history's most spectacular terrorist act were apparently aiming for an impact on the scale of Pearl Harbor — the Japanese surprise attack in December 1941 that traumatized the United States.

"This is the second Pearl Harbor," said Senator Charles Hagel, a Nebraska Republican who was with President George W. Bush in Florida when the attackers struck.

But the initial images of destruction and disorientation may be deceptive, several terrorism analysts cautioned.

Just as the Japanese wartime strike ultimately aroused U.S. fury and led to Tokyo's defeat, Tuesday's stunning blow may trigger a national outrage that escalates U.S. counterterrorist warfare to new international ferocity.

What was stunning about the attacks was their sophistication and coordination. The ability to strike devastating and nearly simultaneous blows in New York and Washington

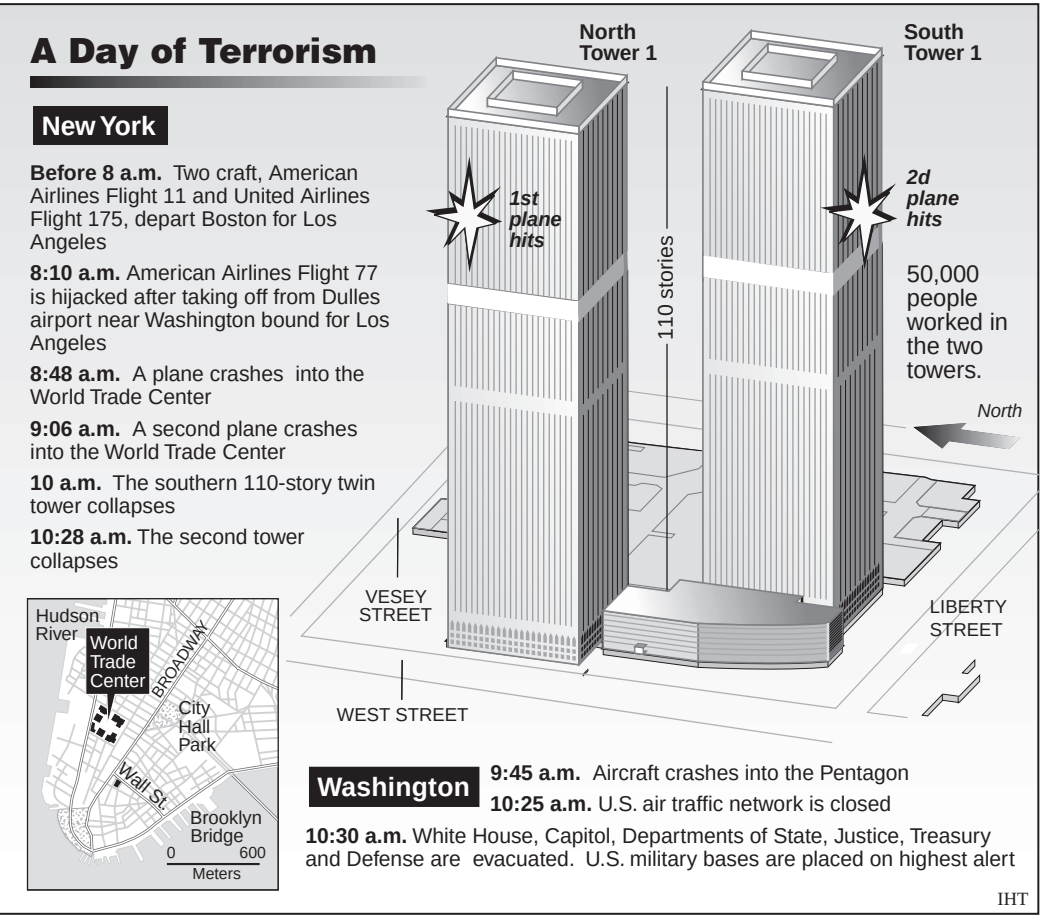
indicated a level of deadly expertise beyond anything the terrorists have ever shown before.

It will take a giant change in U.S. political and military reflexes to match the worldwide impact of the carnage, lethal symbolism and mayhem in the U.S. system achieved by the assaults. That so many targets could be hit at the same time also suggested the vulnerability of America's relatively open borders and loose security.

The deadly attacks Tuesday must have re-

MORE ON THE CRISIS

- **Osama bin Laden warned** three weeks ago of an unprecedented attack because of U.S. support for Israel. Page 9.
- **Most of the world reacted** with horror and condemnation. Page 9.
- **Fear and chaos spread** in the U.S. capital as the Pentagon took a hit. Page 12.



Both Skyscrapers Collapse; Huge Casualties Feared

By Brian Knowlton
International Herald Tribune

WASHINGTON — In a stunning, coordinated terrorist assault on symbols of U.S. economic and military power, two hijacked commercial airliners slammed into the twin towers of New York's World Trade Center on Tuesday, destroying both in calamitous explosions, and a third hijacked plane plowed into the Pentagon building, setting it afire.

Shortly afterward, a Boeing 757 crashed southeast of Pittsburgh, and the authorities said it, too, appeared to have been hijacked.

The heavy casualty toll, sure to make it the worst terrorist attack in U.S. history, and the cold-minded calculation behind the sophisticated strikes stunned America and seemed to push the nation toward a wartime footing.

All commercial air traffic was shut down nationwide for the first time in U.S. history. It was scheduled to resume only at noon Wednesday. The stock markets were closed, and President George W. Bush flew to an air force base in Nebraska, but later was headed back to Washington.

Mr. Bush said U.S. military forces had been put on "high alert," and other nations, too, took significant precautions. Britain placed its defense forces and the police on "full" alert, France activated an anti-terrorist program and Israel took security measures, including closing its borders with Egypt and Jordan.

The attacks aroused concerns in those financial markets that were open, as the dollar dropped sharply and stocks fell on European exchanges. With fears of recession already besetting the world economy, both the U.S. Federal Reserve Board and the European Central Bank issued statements — typically reserved for grave economic circumstances — that they were prepared to inject money into their respective banking systems to help sustain confidence.

While the devastation in New York was so great that the authorities were unable immediately to estimate the number of casualties, it seemed clear that the number of dead and wounded would be at least in the hundreds, and quite possibly the thousands. The four planes that crashed carried more than 260 people, and tens of thousands typically worked in the soaring skyscrapers of the World Trade Center.

"The number of casualties will be more than any of us can bear, ultimately," said Mayor Rudolph Giuliani of New York, who witnessed part of the disaster. "It was the most horrific scene I've ever seen in my whole life."

Victims would include not only some of the thousands in the Trade Center, but also many firefighters and police officers who rushed to the scene and were crushed by falling debris, he said.

Mr. Bush, in his ninth month in office, was immediately confronted with a crisis of vast proportions and with no clear prescriptions. He called the attack "a national tragedy" and pledged to catch the culprits.

"Make no mistake," he said, "the United States will hunt down and punish those responsible for these cowardly acts."

Mr. Bush cut short a Florida visit, but decided not to return to Washington after what were called credible threats against

See ATTACK, Page 12

World Air Traffic Turns Chaotic

By John Schmid and Thomas Crampton
International Herald Tribune

Air traffic around the world was thrown into widespread confusion and congestion Tuesday after the U.S. Federal Aviation Administration canceled all air traffic in the United States until at least 1600 GMT Wednesday.

The total shutdown of U.S. civilian air traffic, the first ever, followed the terrorist attacks in which four scheduled commercial flights crashed after being hijacked. Runways were kept open to allow flights already in the air to land.

"Anybody that is planning on going somewhere isn't going anywhere at least for now," said James Kerr, deputy director at Mitchell International Airport in Milwaukee.

U.S.-bound flights from around the world were canceled and recalled while in flight shortly after the attacks, sending virtually every major international carrier scrambling to reroute flights. Passengers scheduled to land in U.S. cities were left stranded instead in Canada, Ireland, Iceland and Greenland.

Lufthansa, the German flagship carrier, had 22 aircraft over the Atlantic and canceled 15 on the ground. It said some 5,000 passengers on North Atlantic routes were affected.

International airports were put on high security alert in Asia, Europe and Israel, even as many continued to operate non-U.S. routes.

Italian aviation authorities took the added step of canceling flights to the Middle East. In London, Prime Minister Tony Blair halted all commercial air traffic over central London.

"Flight paths to London have been changed so there will be no civil overflights of central London," Mr. Blair said.

Israel banned any foreign airlines from landing at the country's four airports. The ban, however, excluded Israel's own airlines.

Airport operations in Asia were already winding down for the night when the attacks occurred, so only a handful of flights from Hong Kong were immediately affected, said a

See TERROR, Page 12

See FLIGHTS, Page 12